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Art Baron Part II
(The Covid Interview)

The Covid-19 pandemic impacted the music and arts community particularly hard. Musicians who had previously been interviewed for the Fillius Jazz Archive graciously shared their experiences during this virtual shutdown period. The political and racial unrest occurring simultaneously was also addressed.

Art was interviewed via Zoom on June 3, 2020, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm pleased to have Art Baron here with me. And we had the pleasure of an in-person interview a few years ago, and also having Art at Hamilton College. And I thought it would be useful to find out what's going on with him in this particular time of trouble. And generally speaking, Art, how are you doing?

AB: Well I'm about as crazy as everybody else I think. You know it's a big mood swing roller coaster ride we've got going here. But try to practice, and I continue teaching, which is good. I'm getting more and more students to, you know, do it on the internet. And I'm pleased to say you know I use, let's see, unorthodox teaching methods let's say, with movement with visualization, breathing, mindful breathing and meditation and stuff. And it's actually working. I'm pretty happy to say that.

MR: I'm glad you said that because I went back and I was reading your interview and you had described at that time some of the things you did when a person came to your apartment for a lesson. And having them move around the space and sort of resistance, and these very interesting ideas. And I was thinking how would you do that?

AB: Yeah, well are you talking about the "walking through cheese" one?

MR: Yes I am.

AB: Yeah. Man, you can make a kid — an hour of walking through cheese is amazing, and I haven't tried the walking through cheese yet, because I'd like to be moving when I'm doing it and I would — well, when I get my new computer I probably won't need the earphones as much, but maybe I will, or I'll get some speakers or something. But yeah, that could be a challenge but I'm going to give it a shot. I have a new trumpet student that I want to try that with. You know 'cause it's like we've got to make hay while the sun is shining any way we can.

MR: Exactly. You mentioned that you're practicing, I'm wondering about self motivation. How do you deal with down time? Are you motivated or not motivated?

AB: Well it varies. Sometimes I just have to do the "act as if" or "fake it 'til you make it" kind

wonderful CD last fall out in California with a gentleman who has an organization called the American Jazz Institute named Mark Masters and he wrote a bunch of features for me with his big band with a lot of plungers and stuff, and high, with the little mute inside the trombone. And I took two months to make sure my chops were up to being able to do take after take every day for like three days. And you know, so that was an existing goal. So now I have to make my own goals. You know sometimes I try to talk myself into, wow, you know, people are doing a lot of playing online now. What if someone calls me, hey we want you to play "Black, Brown and Beige," "The Work Song" tomorrow. So I've got to be ready for that. So God I just scared myself. We're going to have to cut this short, Monk, I've got to go practice.

MR: Let me know when you get it down and we'll reconvene.

AB: I'm glad you asked me that. That's a good way to look at it. Because it could happen.

MR: It could. That's — I'll have to use that myself. Because I have trouble without goals myself. Like well I could be working on arrangements but when is the next time anybody can gather to play them. It's easy to talk yourself out of it I think.

AB: Yeah, yeah. You're getting to the crux of it.

MR: Yes. Also as a band leader, I wonder what it was like for you to have to call your band mates and say —

AB: Hasta la vista?

MR: Yeah.

AB: Well the last gig, this great gig I had for The Duke's Men, I think I told you about it where I had Bill Crow, the 90 some odd year old bass player, and Bernard Purdie, the great drummer. By the way Purdie swings his butt off. You know I remember meeting him in Richmond, Virginia at a jazz party, oh gosh, probably 30 years ago maybe. And you know these big parties with a whole group of musicians and they put you together. And my first band I played with he was playing drums and I was like oh my God. I told him, we were on radio station BGO right in the beginning of March, before this gig we were to do. And I said, "Pretty, I had to call someone. I think I called my mother." But anyway so we did it. As a matter of fact I'll get you a copy of it once I coalesce, once I can make some CDs. We did this radio show on the NPR radio station BGO down here. And it was March 9th. And our gig was on the 19th. And the talk of the pandemic just started talking, just started happening. And the band was great. And I hadn't led the band in a while and I went back to this management company that gave us great gigs in the late 80s and 90s. And it kind of fizzled out after a while but it was great people. And I knew that a few of them had passed away and a whole new coterie of people were operating it. And at first they weren't interested but I sent them the information and they said, "Sure, send it." Then all of a sudden they kind of got excited. So here I was about to do a big

send one of their agents over. All this was about to happen, and I was like this feels like a resurrection. It feels right. It feels like something to put my time in. And I have this friend of mine named Monk Rowe who got me a gig on October 30, which still are like this. Because I just talked to Purdie last night and I told him about it. Because I wanted to wait just a little more. But good news is better to give than bad news. So so far it's good news man, and we greatly appreciate that.

MR: Yeah.

AB: But anyway it's hard when I have to call people up. They know it. They say yeah we pretty much figured this out. But it's still, it's, I have to do it person by person and I try to stay away from the email magic you know. I like to call.

MR: Yeah. Did you get offered, even with maybe solo work too, people saying well we'll reschedule or — it's very rare for anybody to say you know what? We're going to send you part of the fee?

AB: Like you did.

MR: Yeah.

AB: I've got that money earmarked in my bank account if this all goes south.

MR: That's okay.

AB: It doesn't mean I'm going to give it to you it's just earmarked.

MR: It's earmarked.

AB: Yeah. It should be a good feeling. No. Nothing.

MR: Yeah.

AB: I mean the gentleman who was producing the concert on the 19th, after the radio show he actually offered to give me some money from the money we would make on the 19th to make, just as a little thank you for doing the radio show. It didn't mean I was going to pay him a whole lot. But by the time we got talking again it was like gone. That was before it was cancelled. So we're rescheduled for like 2021.

MR: Right. Is the Musicians Union involved in any kind of support for their members?

AB: They're trying. The Federation, the overall Federation, the union that's for the whole country of which local unions are part of that federation, it kind of sounds like the federation of planets. Star Trek. I wonder what the prime directive of the Federation of Musicians is.

MR: Something like, "find a gig, damn it."

AB: That's it. Prime directive. And so there is a thing called the Emergency Relief Fund which is helping some people. And this is something I hope your listeners hear this, because this is really good to know. People in the performing arts, there's something that our musicians union in New York City got involved with several years ago called the Actors Fund. And those are people you can go to to get some kind of help, even if it's

of their — every year for setting up my Medicare and health insurance and things like that. So there are resources. There are grants available. I know *Coda Magazine* has been issuing some small grants. And there's the Jazz Foundation of America is trying to help. And one other thing, this is not a musical answer, but if you're having trouble with unemployment, like I tried online like crazy 'cause just what's called the Gig or 1099 Unemployment which has been brought into being, and the word Gig actually used to be used for all kinds of freelance work. That's where it came from I found out.

MR: I didn't know that. I thought that was —

AB: I didn't either. That was the ownership by the musicians. No there were several other kinds of freelance work that was called the "gig employment." And so musicians held onto that idea, as far as I can see, the way they talk about it. Well here's what happened: a friend of mine who is politically active, and I know this is not about music but this could help musicians. Because it was impossible. I could not make the website work. And then when I was getting close I got locked out of it. A friend of mine is very politically active, who I am often signing petitions for. I just on a lark I called her. And she found my state senator's office in Albany, and she got a local person there to contact me, you know, someone who works, you know a helper with the senator. And she connected me with unemployment people who called me. And here I mean it is a really detailed thing. You have to apply for the regular, the not gig unemployment, the regular like if you had say a nine to five, five days a week kind of job. You have to apply for that and obviously you will get denied. Then you have to apply for the gig unemployment, or what they call the pandemic — PAU or something, Pandemic something Unemployment. And unemployment called me on the phone, spent about 45 minutes with me. They were actually filling it out. I wasn't online, I was just on the phone. So this is really important. I hope your listeners hear this, find your local senator's office, state senator, and call them. And so if you get people as nice as I got they not only filled it all out online but they walked me through everything, got me denied on the same call, and then applied for the Pandemic Unemployment. And I got it, like a week later or something, it kicked in. I mean so I hope, it's not a musical idea but — well it is musical in that a lot of musicians are in this situation.

MR: That's really good information, I had no idea.

AB: Yeah. You know and I've told people that, because the person that helped me can't help you like if you wanted to do it because you're upstate New York, you have a different senator I would think.

MR: Yes. There was a week, shortly after your last gig, where it seemed like every other day some well known, much loved musicians were showing up in the obit section.

AB: Yeah.

AB: A lot of them. Bucky Pizzarelli. Bucky had a lot of, a lot of friends. I'm not claiming sole ownership, you know, and I didn't see him that much, but as he got older, I met him in a recording session a zillion years ago and he always remembered me. Months could go by and I started — for a while there was this organization at Lincoln Center, not even actually part of Jazz at Lincoln Center, it was PTSPD — not the post traumatic syndrome but similar letters. And they got a lot of nursing home gigs and things like that. And I had great players. I don't know if you remember Fred Staton, you met Fred of course, you know Fred. You knew him. He was in his late 90s when we were doing these gigs. And you know he did — the last gig he did I believe was with my band at an open air church gig down here at St. Mark's Church. He was 102 and he was playing his arse off. And at the end of the gig I said, "Fred, did you have a good time?" He said, "Man, I couldn't find a reed the whole gig." 102. I said — that was just cracked me up. And I looked at him and I said, "Fred, you're still doing it."

MR: Whatever you got give me some.

AB: Yeah. You know? Oh my God. And so I tell you, when Bucky passed, right around the same time the wonderful producer Hal Willner — do you know who he was?

MR: Yes.

AB: I did a lot of projects with him. My first project with him was an amazing project of doing Mingus. It was called "Weird Nightmare: Meditations on Mingus." And I arranged a piece on that, on "Eclipse" in a totally different fashion, not about a black and white person in a couple, but about the first time mankind ever saw an eclipse, cavemen. And we had all these Harry Partch instruments, I played didgeridoo, all kinds of — and he actually got Leonard Cohen to recite some poetry, just a part of a poem that Mingus wrote, "The Chill of Death." Hal was always creating unbelievable groups of people. And you know that's when I got mad at the powers-that-be, and you know who I'm talking about, that those deaths didn't need to happen.

MR: Well I don't mind going to a place in our conversation where — this is not just a conversation about musicians but I'm interested in your general feeling about the state of our country.

AB: Okay. I can tell you that it's gotten clearer to me. The Japanese — I've heard that this may not be true but I heard it so long ago that it was true that I choose to believe it. And the Chinese rather. They have all these symbols for writing the language, and that the symbol for crisis is the same for opportunity, which spiritually speaking makes a lot of sense. I mean the system had gotten so corrupt, let's face it, it's gotten extremely corrupt on both sides of the aisle, more on one than the other, more on the right than the left I think but still corrupt. To make a change, to make a — it's almost like the whole thing had to blow up to make some new grass roots changes and that's what's happened, it's

by day, I tell myself I shouldn't be aghast at that because we know what he's like. I mean so there's so much stuff, including racism now in addition to just poor leadership about the whole pandemic thing. You know standing there, "Well we've got ten cases, it'll be down to five then nothing in a few days, don't worry about it." And then going as far as saying, "Well 100,000 is not bad, we're doing a great job." We're not doing a great job, and people know it. But people also are starting to realize the only way you know when he lies is when he opens his mouth. They used to say that about Bush Senior but it's more real now. And I'm not afraid to speak these things, and I really believe in spiritual change, and I think individual change makes for changes in the world. And a lot of stuff has hit the fan now. It's not easy to be in it, some days I'm really upset. But I think it also is the time of opportunity.

MR: Isn't it interesting, if someone had asked me two weeks ago what kind of incident would replace the newscasters doing it, you know, like here's the first story of my segment, to replace conversation about the pandemic, I would have thought it would have to be like a nuclear explosion or something. And now we have this racial incident sparked in Minneapolis and wow, it has been story number one.

AB: Yeah. The critical mass has been achieved.

MR: Yes.

AB: It's here. Everything is like, no more. And here the answer is, I'm not saying all police are bad, but the answer for a lot of the municipalities is like you know their police get wartime army weapons. You know that's somehow — the illegality of that has been circumvented. Or maybe it's not illegal everywhere. And it's just gotten so like Trump's feeling about it is I'm going to have law and order I don't care how many people I have to kill or tear gas. It's just absurd, his rule, it's totally absurd. He's a monarch in his eyes and he feels like he could do anything he wants. But then there are good people, I love the fact that some of the reports about the good police that are standing with the demonstrators. Demonstrations shouldn't be seen as an affront to our peacetime. Demonstrations are the right of the people. Peaceful assembly. Now I've even heard reports some of the people that are showing up and looting and rioting have been sought out to do that. There is a group of people that does it automatically but it's not the people that are trying to speak a message. I'm not going to get the quote perfect but Martin Luther King said rioting is the language of the unheard. Maybe that is it, what he said. I mean people are not — when — God I can't think of his name, for selling cigarettes in Staten Island and the police killed him with a choke hold. That was like six years ago.

MR: Right.

AB: And it just like we have a chance, and I know people with skin this color are like trying to figure out what do we do now.

AB: Well, as I told you earlier, my wife who is also a Caucasian from Norway, who has never seen anything like this except on the news, and she doesn't want to march, and I understand it because it's really dangerous with the virus too, and I've got my feelings about that, I'm not sure, but she worked on it yesterday and she came home and told me, and she's a bit shy, she gave me an idea that she wanted me to initiate, and I would have initiated it but I really wanted her to. She said, "Let's call up all our black or Afro-American friends" —it's so hard to know what to say, but I think either is acceptable now — "and tell them that we stand with them. And bring the conversation up to another level, bring the relationship up to another level. And you know what? We called several of our friends. I'm very lucky, I played with Stevie Wonder, Duke Ellington, B.B. King, other black groups you know? Jon Faddis used to say to me, "Why don't you play with your own kind?" And I've learned a whole lot. I can never know what it's like to be in the skin of a black man but I can see what it's like and I've seen — and this color of our skin is like, what's the word I'm looking for, we have a leg up.

MR: Yeah, we have a path sort of.

AB: Yeah but there's a great word, white —

MR: Privilege.

AB: Privilege, that's the perfect word. And I don't like that. So we called up all these people and had various responses but all extremely positive. And there was also something, when you bring a conversation up to the next level, when you say what you have to say, there's a pause. Because our black friends hadn't heard anything like this from us. And then they came in and spoke and boy I'll tell you my wife and I were nervous during that pause. Did we do something wrong? Are we too liberal? Are we too something? And it never was the case. And I also have to give credit to my wife Ingvild. Because I said look, she said, "I'm shy, you do the talking." I said, "This is your idea and I don't want it to sound like it was my idea." I asked her about it today. I'm going to put it in FaceBook and make it very clear it's her idea. Because I've been thinking about these issues for years and not knowing what to do about it. What do you do? It's like, you know, I mean Benny Johnson the drummer, I don't know if you ever knew of him, a wonderful black drummer friend of mine. And he drove me to a lot of gigs with The Duke's Men. We got really, really tight. And we covered some ground together and that was good because we spent a lot of time together. But I come from a background of middle white class. Upper middle white class, or middle to upper, where the only blacks I saw were criminals going to prison on television news, and garbage men. And man, you know those tapes, they exist. And like I finally in high school had a couple of black students and a few of them and I got to be friends. You know it's like they're people. I heard, you know a great show to listen to you, you won't get it in the air but online you can get on WNYC public radio

show and it's just continuing. And they bring up all these issues. You know it's just, I mean I think, I mean it took a pandemic and then to have a brutal killing of a man, a man first, then put a black man. Black Lives Matter. And one thing I've got to say, I understand. This is not the time to be spouting out white lives matter too. We got the privilege. We don't need to hear that. What we need to hear is what I just said, Black Lives Matter. And I believe this happened and it was more intense, more stirring the pot because it's during the pandemic. And that's good. I mean it's not good he got killed. Nothing good about it. But if we can make something good come out of it then we're being blessed.

MR: Thanks for sharing that. Very important.

AB: Yeah and I hope if you're listening people, take a chance. Even if it's like you go into a store and a black man or a Hispanic man is running it, or woman, or friends, anything, just speak the truth. Hopefully it is your truth that you want to let them know you stand by them.

MR: Do you have predictions about — let's suppose and let's hope that this pandemic fades away. What do you think is going to be the landscape for live performances in the future?

AB: I think it's going to take some time for people to really trust — although you know it's funny because there's an air in New York City, even though we're walking around with masks on, there's this sense, and spring is here, almost summer is here, that it's all gone. You know? And like sometimes when I go to wash my hands for 20 seconds many times a day I say oh I can do 15 seconds it's pretty cool. And no, you've got to do 20 seconds. I'm like washing the skin off my hands. I'm not doing it with the same exuberance I did three weeks ago but I'm still doing it. But the thoughts are like oh this is over. We have a little park near us and my wife and I walk there a couple of times a week, fully masked, and get a coffee or something. And you see people, a lot of people with masks, but a lot of people just sitting too close together. You know? And so I think it might just — the simple answer is I think it might be — well there's two ways to look at it. There's the people who want to be careful about putting a lot of people in chairs in a room, and then the people say come on let's just do it. It's over. You know.

MR: Well it's interesting you say that because you and I have a gig scheduled and I would love to be able to say yeah, get all your people in line, we're going to do it. But even if — like we got some positive news regarding the fall semester and students coming back, but even then you may have students on campus but they may say something like no large gatherings, in a concert hall everybody has to sit like six seats apart or something. Those things are going to be dealt with and it's very hard to predict.

AB: Is — I've forgot already, where we'll perform, is it the same place that the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band played?

AB: So that's not a very large space.

MR: It's not a large space.

AB: Say it again?

MR: It's not that large a space but maybe other arrangements could be made but we'll see. I'm saying on tape that if we can't do the fall then we're going to do it sometime.

AB: Bless you. So I don't have to give the deposit back. Great. I love it.

MR: But I could use a loan now that you did so well with unemployment.

AB: Watch what you say, Baron. Well I appreciate that and I appreciate that it's on tape. I would have trusted you even if it wasn't on tape. You have a good reputation my man.

MR: Well just to wrap up, this is a funny question about how you feel about yourself. We have, so used to playing gigs, that's what we do. And being in front of people. And that's what we do. And now we can't do it.

AB: That's the premium question. It's not a funny question, it's a great question. Because working on myself is something I've been doing much of my adult life, changing who I believe I am. And it's given me pause to look at, wow, a lot of — I don't want to say self-esteem but I'm used to adulation. I'm used to the thing where I play for someone, ten people, a thousand people, two hundred, it doesn't matter. And this energy — not even the words, "Oh you sounded great," but the energy back and forth between us, I realized that I define myself from that. And it's like it's not the total definition but it's a good part. And I'll be honest with you and say something that you may not know — it's been an issue. I did not have an easy childhood of support. And I rebelled against it. And I've had to work much of my adult life to feel good about what I do and I've really reached a great place on it. As a matter of fact, coming home from that radio show I felt man, all this was worth it. I feel so good, what I do, I'm one of these elders and sitting there with Bill Crow and Purdie, and I was telling them I was saying all of those youngsters and me you know, almost an oldster, really appreciate you guys. And Bill Crow said, "Well you're an up-and-coming oldster yourself." Something like that. And I really realized like for so many years I've been accepted and it's coming in like gangbusters now. And so it's like God damn I feel so good about myself and this, and then the pandemic comes. You know? So it's taken some work you know. And I know I just exposed myself, because most people don't have a clue about that. "Oh you're great, you get up there and you take care of business" you do this, you do that. Yeah. And they're right. So it's a heavy time right now. I think a lot of people are working internally on themselves now.

MR: Thank you for saying that. I experienced just a little bit of that when I got hired to do, with a bunch of other people, like, "Do a concert from your home" for a local arts center. They're going to broadcast it. So we set up a camera.

AB: Was that you alone or with other people online. Say it again it broke up.

MR: Yeah by myself. So mostly I play piano also and so mostly it was that, but that feeling that we usually get, okay the song is over and we know what's supposed to happen. We get this adulation, right? So you're doing this film and you finish it and you look at the camera and it's like [sighs] like nothing. And it exposes what you were saying about that, needing that adulation.

AB: Yeah. My wife is a singer and we started doing online things. We do stuff for the local St. Mark's Church here, part of the service every once in a while. And a friend of ours came to us, a young lady and she is part of this Gowanus Canal Conservancy and they have a big gala every year. And this year they couldn't have it so they had it online. They asked us to perform for a half hour and then to talk a little bit about the whole Conservancy and stuff. She gave me some talking points. Now I wasn't sure how I was going to do that without hearing people or seeing people. There were thousands of people I think were watching this. And all of a sudden I got into the groove of like knowing that people were hearing us but it was like at first it was just hard to gather some kind of instinctual way of doing this, but it worked out. My wife and I worked up some songs like "It's a Wonderful World" and "What the World Needs Now" is love sweet love. I did "Summertime" I think by myself or something like that — oh, "Ain't Misbehavin'" I think I did. Something like that. A couple of things by myself. And it was like the ham in me came out even though there was no one standing or sitting in front of me.

MR: Well you keep "Ain't Misbehavin'" or however you want to turn that around, keep behaving. And I knew this would be an informative and appropriate conversation, Art, and I'm going to stop recording but we can chat a little bit more.

AB: Sure.

MR: All right. Thank you very much.

AB: I'll tell you the real story then.

MR: Okay.